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Nicodemus

The teacher of Israel who came to Jesus by night and stood by him in the end.

Nicodemus was a Pharisee and "a ruler of the Jews," a respected teacher in Jerusalem. He appears only in John's Gospel, and only three times. First he comes to Jesus by night and hears that he must be "born again." Later he speaks up for Jesus in the council and is mocked for it. Last, he joins Joseph of Arimathea in burying Jesus with a costly load of spices. John never says when Nicodemus came to faith, but his three scenes trace a man moving slowly out of the shadows and into the open.

At a glance

Name	Greek <i>Nikodemos</i> , usually explained as "victor over the people"
Group	A Pharisee (John 3:1)
Position	"A ruler of the Jews," probably of the Sanhedrin (John 3:1)
Title	"A master of Israel," meaning a teacher (John 3:10)
When	c. AD 28–30, during Jesus' ministry
Key places	Jerusalem
Key people	Jesus, the chief priests and Pharisees, Joseph of Arimathea
New Testament	Only in John's Gospel (John 3:1–21; 7:45–52; 19:38–42)

"Jesus answered and said unto him, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God."

John 3:3, KJV

The life of Nicodemus

Dates are approximate (AD) and follow the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30. On the other main view (AD 33), add about three years.

- c. AD 28–29

Passover

● Comes by night

At Passover in Jerusalem many believe when they see Jesus' miracles. Nicodemus comes to Jesus by night and calls him "a teacher come from God," because no one could do such signs unless God were with him. *John 2:23–3:2*
- The same night

● Hears of new birth

Jesus tells him a man must be "born of water and of the Spirit." Nicodemus asks, "How can these things be?" Jesus speaks of the Son of man being lifted up, as Moses lifted up the serpent. *John 3:3–15*
- c. AD 29

Feast of tabernacles

● Speaks up in the council

Officers sent to arrest Jesus return empty-handed. When the Pharisees scorn the crowd, Nicodemus asks whether the law judges a man before hearing him. They answer, "Art thou also of Galilee?" *John 7:45–52*
- c. AD 30

The day of the crucifixion

● Helps bury Jesus

With Joseph of Arimathea he brings about a hundred pounds of myrrh and aloes. They wind Jesus' body in linen with the spices and lay it in a new tomb in a nearby garden. *John 19:38–42*

Group notes

Key activities

John does not say why Nicodemus came by night. Some think he feared the other leaders, others that night was simply a quiet time for study. Many also notice John's theme of light and darkness (John 3:19-21).

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- 1 Came to Jesus.** He sought Jesus out and honoured him as a teacher from God because of the signs he had done. *John 3:1-2*
 - 2 Asked honest questions.** He asked how a grown man could be born again, and then, "How can these things be?" *John 3:4, 9*
 - 3 Heard the heart of the gospel.** In this conversation he heard that God so loved the world that he gave his only begotten Son. *John 3:14-17*
 - 4 Stood up for fairness.** He reminded the council that the law does not judge a man before hearing him. *John 7:50-51*
 - 5 Bore the council's scorn.** The others mocked him as if he were a Galilean follower, and told him to search the Scriptures. *John 7:52*
 - 6 Gave a costly burial.** He brought about a hundred Roman pounds of myrrh and aloes, roughly seventy pounds by modern weight, a gift fit for a king. *John 19:39*
 - 7 Stepped into the open.** With Joseph of Arimathea he handled Jesus' body publicly on the day the council had condemned him. *John 19:38-40*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Nicodemus.

Old Testament

Numbers 21:8–9	The brass serpent, Jesus' picture for Nicodemus (John 3:14–15)
Echo: Ezekiel 36:25–27	Clean water, a new heart and a new spirit
Echo: Deuteronomy 1:16–17	Judges must hear a matter fairly

New Testament

John 3:1–21	The night talk; where Jesus' words end is debated
John 7:45–52	He defends a fair hearing for Jesus
John 19:38–42	He helps Joseph of Arimathea bury Jesus
Echo: John 12:42–43	Rulers who believed but feared to confess
Echo: 1 Peter 1:23	Born again by the word of God

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Nicodemus say about Jesus when he first came to him (John 3:2)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Jesus answered with "Ye must be born again" (John 3:7) rather than talking about his miracles?
3. *Apply:* Nicodemus came with honest questions. What question about faith would you like to bring to God in prayer this week?
4. *Apply:* In John 7 Nicodemus spoke up for fairness in a hostile room. Where could you speak a quiet word for what is fair this week?